two commented lines followed by a directive of `memory_limit = 256M`, which sets a maximum of *256* megabytes that can be allocated for a single running PHP process (any memory allocation above this limit will terminate the script immediately with an error message). Valid values for directives depend on the directive itself: for example `memory_limit` will accept an integer value for bytes or shorthand for large units (such `1G` for 1 gigabyte), `log_errors` accepts either `On` or `Off` to enable or disable error logging.

It is permitted to use PHP constants (special symbols that are used in PHP programs, see Chapter 2, "Data, Types, and Variables," for more detail) in `php.ini` files, it is very common to see the `error_reporting` directive set to some combination of the error logging constants, for example, `error_reporting = E_ALL`, which translates as "show every type of error." See Chapter 4, "Logic and Control," for more details on PHP errors and how to handle them. Be aware that language constants aren't universally available (it's not possible to use them to set directives via the Windows registry, for example).

System Search Paths

When PHP starts up (either as a web-server module, via CGI, or the command line), it will search certain paths for these `.ini` files and read the contents looking for directives and their values. The filesystem path(s) that are searched will be configured during compilation of the PHP C source code and will vary by platform. We won't be covering compiling PHP from source in this book, but it is easy enough to determine which path your particular PHP binary will use.

```
$ php --ini
Configuration File (php.ini) Path: /etc/php/8.4/cli
Loaded Configuration File:         /etc/php/8.4/cli/php.ini
Scan for additional .ini files in: /etc/php/8.4/cli/conf.d
...
```

If the file `php.ini` exists, it will be read for config directives; in addition, if there is a SAPI-specific file such as `php-cli.ini`, then it will take precedence:

```
$ sudo cp /etc/php/8.4/cli/php.ini /etc/php/8.4/cli/php-cli.ini
$ php --ini
Configuration File (php.ini) Path: /etc/php/8.4/cli
Loaded Configuration File:         /etc/php/8.4/cli/php-cli.ini
...
```